

Revalorization of the Native Image in Shona Proverbial Lores: An Atriaesthetic Perspective

by

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When people like me, they like me "in spite of my color". When they dislike me; they point out that it isn't because of my color. Either way, I am locked in to the infernal circle. - **Frantz Fanon**

ABSTRACT

This article is anticipated as a contribution to the mounting body of books and papers on African aesthetics by presenting both of the African and Western concepts of beauty and the black experience. Many nationalists, pan-Africanists, patriotists, independent church leaders, anti-apartheid activists among other Africans have written many books and articles and at times made use of orature or oral literature, as a way of divulging colour based racism, but I have opted to rise my right hand and start to put down on paper the same issue again but using a new perspective aligned with our native colour based Shona proverbial lores (*Tsumo* or *Shumo*) in particular and Africa in general because racial segregation during the colonial and post-colonial epoch never fully faded away from our 'psychic consciousness'. In the history of African racial relations, perpetrators of racism appear to have been largely white while the victims of the ploy have been largely black. This article seeks to obliterate the burden of black racism and seeks to revalorize and rebuild black people's lost identity due to the demono-dictums regarding the native's skin by the amalgamation of the so-called black consciousness and black skin aesthetics (0Atriaesthetic perspective).

Keywords: Atriaestheticism, Africology, Black consciousness, Mythology, Beauty, Proverb, Shona, Ubuntu

DEDICATION: This article is dedicated to my beautiful Africana mother (*mhai*) culturally, Esther Muwandi with whom I found her inner beauty since my father's sudden death in 2012 till now. The way she became my father, yes I mean it 'my father', her role as both of a mother and father is appreciated.

INTRODUCTION

The Shona (*VaShona*) is a particular group among the Bantu people in Southern Africa that inhabits an area between Zambezi and Limpopo rivers, it is the largest tribal group in Zimbabwe (Southern Rhodesia by then). The perception of beauty in Africa has gradually changed from its traditional conception and its basis or foundation is failing. The way precolonial African people euphorized the concept of beauty has changed. Traditional Shona people understood beauty in holistic terms, but as we will see, it has changed (Mapara & Matereke, 2009:2). I am comparing the distinction between Afrocentric and Eurocentric definitions of beauty (*kunaka*) primarily because Europeans were the ones who were at the forefront in the dehumanization and decontinentalization of Africans and Africa respectively, due to their malicious activities to an extent of annihilating African people's colour thereby, losing our integrity, morality and dignity during the colonial epoch. The kind of wretchedness I have in mind is that which was prompted by the systematic denial to black people of access to social goods such as education, decent housing, water and electricity supplies, health and any other social goods during and after the colonial epoch that would have not only made their lives gratifying or enjoyable but would have provided an arena for black people to improve their lives and secure their own future and the future of their own descendants. Colour segregation prevailed in the churches, school, prisons, residential areas, hospitals, the courts and many other institutions. The Shona proverb (one major type of orature) is going to be applied in this article as a vituperative and vitiating weapon in deconstructing all of the European mythological statements regarding blacks in the interior and diaspora and being able to divulge the autonomy of being black. Whiting (1932:27); succinctly observes that, a proverb is

[a] short saying of philosophical nature, of great antiquity, the product of the masses rather than of the classes, constantly applicable and appealing because it bears a semblance of the universal truth.

In this case, these proverbs are based on African worldview, and are simply revealing the assumptions and presumptions that Africans use in perceiving what true beauty is. Literature remain strong due to the use of oral tradition literature (Kahari, 1990: 36). Orature is a major aspect among Africans in-land and in the diaspora that is able to expose their various ways of recognizing the world around them. Spoken word is much powerful as compared to the written symbol (Finnegan, 1970:3). In this case, proverbs are acting as Shona people's (in particular and Africans in general) reservoir of their cultural norms, history and beliefs and at the same time revealing the truth concerning Africa and Africans in the interior and in the diaspora. This notion is clearly disclosed by a Yoruba proverb which states that;

Bi oro ba sonu owe ni a fi nwa.

Proverbs are horse-footed to solve a problem, when the truth is elusive, it is proverbs that we use to discover it.

In relation to the underlying meaning of the Yoruba proverb above, Lestrade in Mberi (1996:66), affirms that,

The didactic role of proverbs is enhanced by the fact that most of them are general universal truths and that is why I refers to them as “mere platitudinous truism”.

The Yoruba proverb mentioned previously is simply revealing the significance of Yoruba proverbs in particular and Africa in general, the way it is important in Yoruba tradition, so also it is important in other African communities. So, proverbial lores as chief type of orature in Africa, are able to ‘reflect the conscious and unconscious thoughts of its producers’ (Mberi, 1996: 65). Consciousness is the relaxation of a person's psychic. According to Mapara and Matereke (2009:16);

These proverbs are not an indication of a disregard for physical beauty. Beautiful women and handsome men were desired but beauty did not have to be the main criterion for determining a marriageable person.

Hence, this paper is going to explicate the notion of beauty and beautiful in Africa by recognizing the beauty of the colour black and beauty within.

METHODOLOGY

This study has been done by consulting both of primary and secondary sources. Some of these sources include hard and soft copy library books, and papers, songs and videos.

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

We need our own Africana theorists, not scholars who duplicate or use theories created by others in analyzing Africana texts. Hudson-Weems in (Tembo, 2012:58).

The theoretical framework that enlightens this paper is that of Atriaesthetic perspective as it relates to Africa and its people. Etymologically, the morphologic and neologicistic amalgamated Atriaesthetic originates from the researcher's lexical adulteration of two Latin words 'atri' and 'aesthetic' meaning black and a sense of beauty respectively, to formulate an Africana phenomena in cultural terms. Aesthetics is a branch of philosophy, which concerns itself with the essence of beauty. Atriaestheticism is by definition, the acceptance of the various dimensions of beauty encompassing the artistic black beauty and taste as fundamental and necessary standards that inspires and revalorize rather than marginalizes and devalorize African peoples' images reflected about their lives. Atriaestheticism seeks to eradicate the burden of black racism and seeks to revalorize and rebuild black people's lost identity due to the malicious dictums regarding the native skin. This ground-breaking theory is drawing inspiration from Afrocentricity and heroic aspects of the African heritage that seek to restore a sense of respect, dignity, and courage to Africans after all they were going through during the colonial epoch. For instance, because of the lack of wisdom, Europeans end up using the axiom 'Black People' as a demonym to describe Africans. At the forefront of such indictments have been Biko promulgated that, 'Being black is not a matter of pigmentation- being black is a reflection of a mental attitude.' Being black is not a curse and bad of shame, incisively, the colour black at its essence is what gives us (African people) integrity, dignity and good moral behaviour. I always wonder why some of our African brothers and sisters feel like outsiders wherever they meet a White person even if they are in their own native land. According to Maveneke (1970:94);

Since the coming of the white man into this country, the indigenous people have undergone rapid change... We all know that the people of this country had a different way of life before 1890.

Man's way of thinking has changed, meaning and value of African life have changed due to colonialism. Due to invasion of Europeans in Africa and their association with Africans, '*things fall apart*' literary in our culture and that is where the '*wretched of the earth*' begins. Some of the African generations today are now becoming the puppets of the whites, mimicking and imitating the whiteman's culture, for instance, way of dressing, colour, language, music to mention but a few, and Africa itself goes through an upheaval. They forget the notion that, 'Beauty is only skin deep'. One is not supposed to be ashamed of being a black person because black is beautiful and black people are forever. Everyone is beautiful as long you are causing pleasure, and this pleasure can be more or less intense and perceived in different ways. Pleasure always counts in rating a human being's aesthetic experience.

DEFINITION OF THE TERM BEAUTY (KUNAKA)

The term beauty is derived from the Greek word "κάλλος" which means "good" or "of fine quality". Beauty by definition, are the qualities that give pleasure to the senses. The Oxford dictionary defines it (beauty) as:

"A combination of qualities, such as shape, colour, or form that pleases the aesthetic senses, especially the sight".

Researcher's equivalent Shona meaning;

Uyu mubatanidzwa wezvinhu, zvakaita sechimiro, ruvara, nezvimwewo uye zvichinyevenutsa pfungwa dzemunhu kusanganisira meso.

Relying on the aforementioned definition, there are many qualities that constitutes to the sensation of beauty. To put it more frankly, everyone is beautiful but in a different dimension as compared to the other. The philosopher and teacher, Confucius said of beauty, "Everything has beauty but not everyone sees it." From the definition of beauty, there are no colour variations in explicating what real beauty is, for instance, whether whiteness or blackness brings out the sense of beauty. This is where the gist of this paper is, in demythifying the European colour based mythological statements.

The idea of beauty which is relative to culture and traditions, amazingly hinges on two dimensions; the inner and the outer forms. To be in particular, Shona people and Africans in general have their definite idea and requirements of what constitutes to the real meaning of beauty in their society and being able to read the underlying motives of a good person (*munhu akanaka*). Edel and Edel in Gelfand (1973:54) have stressed in their book that, ‘...there are variations in ethical and moral practices from one country to another.’ From the above statement, it is clear that, the definition of the term beauty (*kunaka* as translated in the Shona vernacular) fluctuates from one culture to another. This is also strengthened by vibrant Shona proverbs which act as vivacious or vital force in the service of moralizing the society’s ideology when it is in danger of changing (Kahari, 1990:144). For instance;

Kunaka hakunakirwani.

(Beauty varies according to a person).

The above Shona proverb is connotatively translated in an English proverbial lore which says; ‘One man’s meat is another man’s poison.’ Hume in Omosoria asserted that,

Beauty is no quality in things themselves: It exists merely in the mind which contemplates them; and each mind perceives a different beauty. One person may even perceive deformity, where another is sensible of beauty; and every individual ought to acquiesce in his own sentiment, without pretending to regulate those of others.

From Hume’s words, the way a person observes the sense of beauty cannot be the same as by another. In this manner, there are two major approaches in which the term ‘beauty’ is defined, Afrocentric (which is representing the indigenous) and Eurocentric (modern) approaches.

AFROCENTRIC DEFINITION OF BEAUTY

The concept of beauty in Africa is intertwined with the *Ubuntu* philosophy or *Hunhuism* (Humanity to others). Similarly, we cannot talk of *Hunhu* in Africa in general and Zimbabwe in precise without the mention of ancestors (*Vadzimu*) and precolonial Shona elders (*Griots* as termed by D. T Nian in *Epic of Sundiata*) because they are at the centre of it all. African ancestral spirits contributed exclusively to a person’s good moral behaviour and character. ‘An individual who has the protective support of his ancestral spirits can be certain that all will go well for him and..., his character will be good’ (Gelfand, 1973: 56). A wise man once said, ‘the older the moon, the

brighter it shines’, that is the easiest way of describing these Shona elders. Everything told by the ancestors was intended to teach, they simply got the wisdom from experience.

Broadly speaking, Shona proverbs have a double role or function: one is juridical and the other one educational. They verbalize customary law and enunciate rules of conduct in life. (Hamutyinei and Plangger, 1987: xix)

The above statement explains the idea why there was [is] the application of the tense sign maker (*-ka*) in Shona proverbs, meaning it was something from the past and the use of the tense sign maker (*-no*) meaning it is intended to teach the present. For example;

Charovedzera charovedzera; gudo rakakwira mawere kwasviba

(What is experienced is experienced/ the baboon climbed a precipice after dark)

AND

Zino irema rinosekerera newarisingadi.

(A tooth is a fool; it smiles even at those it does not love).

So these proverbs were conveyed culturally by Shona ancestors with the main idea of informing and teaching, abiding with *hunhu* or *ubuntu*. According to Sibanda (2014: 2), ‘In the Zimbabwean African sense, *hunhu* / *ubuntu* is what characterises a perfect human being.’ By the application of the phrase, ‘perfect human being’ at times meaning, *munhu akanakisa*, explicates that, for a person in Africa to be called ‘beauty’, he or she must attain certain qualities of *hunhu* or *ubuntu* which will be mentioned as this paper unfolds. Figure 1.0 designates that beauty in an Afrocentric sense or point of view progresses with a person’s moral behaviour or *hunhu* / *ubuntu*. In all African societies during the early epoch,

The individual at every stage of life had a series of duties and obligations to others in the society as well as a set of rights: namely, things that he or she could expect or demand from other individuals. (Rodney, 1973: **How Africa Developed Before the Coming of the Europeans up to the 15th Century**).

In the centuries before the contact with Europeans, Africans deal with their problems in a positive manner by applying the humanistic values they have inherited and perpetuated from their ancestors. Hence, in relation with the issue of beauty, a person gets more beautiful in Africa when

he or she have others on heart and living as one mega family. This view is revealed by a Shona proverb which affirms that;

Kuwanda huuya / chakaipa kupedzerana usavi.

(To be many is good, but bad when it comes to finishing relish).

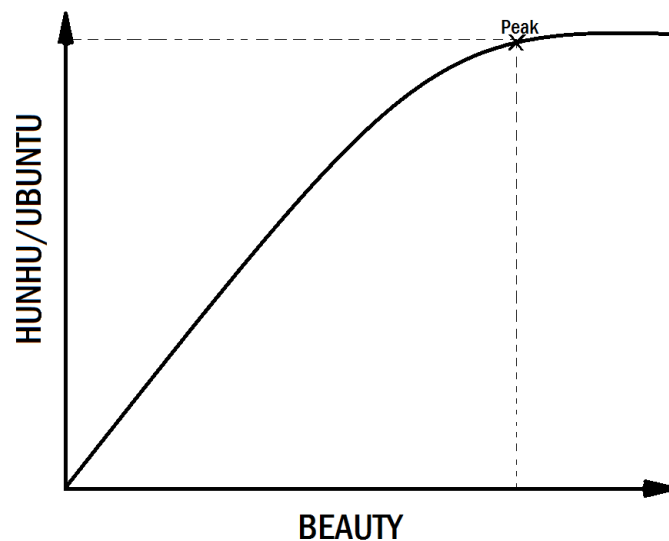
OR

Imbwa mbiri hadzitorerwi nyama.

(Meat cannot be taken away from two dogs).

The aforementioned proverbs postulate that, in Africa, togetherness is how we stand and succeed in our daily lives and otherness is how we fall. This is how beauty works in Africa, having *hunhu* or *ubuntu*. The graph below represents an African definition of beauty which mainly counts from inside.

Figure 1.0: Afrocentric definition of beauty



What we can get from the fore-going is that beauty in Africa is functional and it is linked to a person's character, and what characterises a beautiful person in Africa is *hunhu* or *ubuntu*. Hence, Beauty increases with *hunhu*, the more *hunhu* one has, the more beautiful he or she is. This is the easiest way of clarifying it.

Mostly, Africans do consider the inner beauty of a person rather than outer beauty as opposed to the Europeans and other Western countries who consider the outer or physical beauty wholly. Rendering Gelfand's words (1981:90);

Thus beauty is found in all forms of life – in animals and plants and also in the natural environment such as the earth, the sea and the sky. Many people know that beauty is only “skin deep”

Gelfand here supports the idea that, in Africa, the true definition of beauty encompasses a plethora of aspects like, discipline, morality, altruism, responsibility and duty, good behaviour (*tsika*), generous, being able to dress in an African way, not greedy, abiding to the ancestral lores and laws, music, dance to mention but a few, are all definitive of beauty. To be in particular, some songs of Okot p'Bitek which sometimes be judged as aesthetic objects, exposes an extent of what really constitutes to the idea of beauty in African societies, for instance, in the Song of Lawino, she (Lawino) is the centre of the quarrel in her song. Igwe (1975: 20) argues that;

Her world is that of traditional African culture... we see Clementine through Lawino's extremely biased eyes, and the image is that of extreme ugliness. But the ugliness does not really stop at physical unattractiveness.

Okot p'Bitek is simply revealing the clash of cultures precisely African and European. Clementine ended up being ugly because she wants to be like a white woman, everything about her is artificial, for instance, her skin, hair and entire figure. Lawino is representing an African race while Clementine is imitating the other (European). Merriam (1964) describes three main domains of music which are the sound, behaviour and concept. These traits of sound and behaviour as the major aspects of the aesthetics in African music is revealed by Kahari when he revealed the importance of the combination between music and dance among Shona people by the use of the Shona expression *zvitambo nengoma* (the dance and the drum). He argues that;

The dance is almost incomplete without the accompaniment of the drum, and anything that appeals to our sense of aesthetics is described as *zvitambo nengoma* (the dance and the drum), emphasizing the compatibility that exist between the two (Kahari, 1990: 127).

In the case of Lawino, Okot p'Bitek manages to reveal the beauty within African music and how great the music is in Africa showing the cultural aesthetic values of the African people all over the

world. Most of the African qualities of beauty are not easily detectable until one performs or acts meaning that beauty is in-bone or inside. This is strengthened by a Shona proverbial lore which states that;

Huswa hwenyati ndohuri mudumbu, huri pamuromo inofa nahwo.

(The grass eaten by a buffalo is in the stomach, that one in the mouth will die with it).

For one to understand the above proverb, he or she must be an insider of African culture and should have certain knowledge concerning Africa to understand the embedded meaning of the proverbial lore, because that proverb is simply revealing the importance of the inside beauty rather than physical attractiveness. The notion of beauty in Africa as form of art that is celebrated it is functional, 'there is no art just for art's sake' (p'Bitek, 1986). Beauty in Africa is associated with the living and the living dead. Concerning this canon, Omosoria noted that,

Beauty from the African point of view entails, functionalism, communalism/collectiveness and commitment. These three aspects encompass the beauty of Africa in every circle since from the European point of view beauty is said to lie in the eyes of the beholder. Instead from the African perspective, the concept of beauty has to have a purpose which it fulfils.

So the word beauty in Africa is not just a mere word but it is loaded. For one to be called beauty which sometimes be called 'a good person' *munhu akanaka*, is supposed to attain certain qualities like those I have mention in the beginning of this topic. Matiza in Ibanga (2017:7) argues that;

'From African perspective, the concept of beauty has to have a purpose which it fulfils.'
Beauty must serve to communicate values, norms, morals, and purpose. Beauty must edify the community.

Even though many people especially in the West, do prefer physical beauty, but too much of it may cause danger to the society. This is clearly revealed by a Shona proverb which says;

Mukadzi mutsvuku / kusaba anoroya

A beautiful woman who does not turn out to be a thief becomes a witch.

To marry an outstanding beautiful woman is playing with fire (Gelfand, 1981:91).Relating to the above proverbial lore, Gelfand goes on to say;

Some may even liken her to a witch. The Shona believe that real beauty includes that of a person's character. Although a pretty or handsome person is admired personality and behaviour are considered of greater value.

Africans do consider the inner beauty much when looking for a lover for marriage because what gives a human being beauty and exquisiteness is the attitude and character. In Annang of Nigeria, the word *ntuen-akpo* is used metaphorically to refer to a woman who only has physical attractiveness, but lack good manners (Ibanga, 2017:7). *Ntuen-akpo* is a type of attractive pepper that can hurt the tongue when tasted or eaten. Yes, pepper is adorable at its outside appearance but its taste cannot even be compared to that of a *tsubvu* fruit (Smelly berry). In spite of a woman's sparkling physical beauty, her real beauty is drawn from her manners. Another Afrocentered definition of beauty among women is concealed in the Shona proverb with sates that;

Mukadzi akanaka / ndoune mukutu.

A good wife is the one with a quiver (carrying cloth).

The aforesaid proverb is supporting the idea that, beauty in a woman can also be defined by the way of dressing, particularly in an African way. Skin colour and a person's good looking face are not all definitive qualities in rating a beautiful woman in African culture. For instance, in the novel *Gwararenhamo* (1991), there is a beautiful woman called Bhiyuti (Beauty). She is beautiful but also very dangerous. The author shows that, 'beauty which has no matching positive deeds, is worthless' (Mapara, 2003:50). So when there are such circumstances like the above, there is need to consider the inner beauty which can only be attained from a person's positive actions. Oliver Mtukudzi's song *Dzoka Uyamwe* (Come back and suck) openly elucidated the African concept of beauty which only counts from inside. The persona astutely notes that;

Mandiona kusviba mati kuora

Kundiona kusviba mati kuora

Mandiona kusviba mati kuora

Kundiona kusviba hunzi kuora

Kuora kwemunhu kuri mumoyo

Kusviba kwemunhu kuri mupfungwa

Kuora kwemunhu kuri mumoyo varume

Kusviba kwemunhu kuri mupfungwa

(You have seen me black and thought I have decayed

Seen me black and thought I have decayed

You have seen me black and thought I have decayed

Seen me black meaning I have decayed

A person's decay is in the heart

A person's blackness is in the mind

A person's decay is in the heart brethren

A person's blackness is in the mind)

The above stanza is being supported by the daily usage Shona metaphorical expression by Shona people, *Une moyo wakasviba* (You are a dirt-hearted person) referring to a bad-mannered person, meaning a person's true character is defined by his or her heart or mind. The poet understands culture from 'the native's point of view' Malinowski in (Morris, Leung, Daniel & Lickel, 1999:1). From the preceding statement, Mtukudzi wrote the song above in the manner he did using an emic and etic approach because he is an insider of African culture, he is simply revealing the beliefs of African personnel in general and Shona people in particular.

EUROCENTRIC DEFINITION OF BEAUTY

The European or Western notion of beauty is completely different to that of Africa and this is so because of the different worldviews culturally. The word beautiful in the Western culture is greatly associated with the outer or physical appearance. This notion is supported by Metzner (2012: 1) who states that, the word beauty is considered to be Middle English, and originated from the Old French word *beauté*, which means "physical attractiveness, goodness, and courtesy". The definition above is supporting the idea of beauty from outside as the real definitive of beauty. For instance, they (Whites) do consider certain physical qualities like skin colour, not malformed, good looks to mention but a few. Grube in Ibanga (2017: 2), observes that;

In Greek culture the word "beautiful" referred mainly to physical attractiveness that was anthropocentric. But the concept of beauty did not attract the attention of Western philosophers until Plato.

From the quotation above, physical appearance is what truly define a person's beauty in the Western culture. But at times rating a person's beauty using outer appearance may be hazardous. This is revealed by Nwala in Njiofor (2018:7) using an Igbo figurative language expression;

Qma n'anya

Beautiful only in the eye

The expression above according to Njiofor, 'when used for a human being means that certain other basic qualities especially good conduct and character are lacking; and that it could also mean beauty that does not endure.' In the context of European culture, the concepts of beauty and beautiful are indeed unique as compared to that of Africa. Europeans relate white colour to anything that is purified and holy and black as ugly and evil. Even to the present day, some of the White people are passing this hate to their progenies due to the use of some figurative languages that are sometimes racial and upholds the idea of compartmentalism, for instance, there is a rumor that, a coloured child love his or her white parent more than a black one and a white parent do not love his or her coloured child that much because of the blackness in him or her. A relevant example can be drawn from a particular movie by Anne Bancroft named *Deep in my Heart* (1999). There is a girl named Barbara who is quarreling with her white mother about her rapist father who was black and she said he made the black part of her ugly, she goes on to say, 'And I have no great history with white people'. That culture of equating black to evil and ugly is clearly elucidated by a Turkish proverb which says;

Coffee should be black as hell; strong as death, and sweet as love.

In contrast with the above proverb, the biblical saga says, 'hell is filled with fire' and the colour of fire is far from being black but almost red and this kind of confusion left people in a dilemma and religious ambivalence. That culture of relating everything evil to the colour black is alien and new to Africa. Due to the coming of the whites, we have learned that, 'new is dangerous' because it destroys. This is a very clever way of putting it. African culture was destroyed by Europeans but never defeated. When Europeans fight against Africans, they suddenly discovered that these Africans were something more than *instrumenta vocalia*. There is only one reason why Europeans perceive something as beautiful the way they do, it is mainly because of the so-called Victorian racial thinking. This type of thinking among Europeans led to the emergence of the mythos against Africa and Africans that were formulated by Europeans themselves deliberately to erase African

people's image, letting them leave like an anomie and creating a room for themselves to penetrate into the interior.

EUROPEAN MYTHS REGARDING BLACKS AND BLACK COLOUR

Not only are European mythological statements regarding African people's colour one of the most severe expressions of discrimination, it also constitutes a grave abuse of a person's dignity. Mythological statements are based on or told of in traditional stories; lacking factual basis or historical validity. Becoming the victim of racialism has repercussions for people who are targeted, as well as for their families, communities and society as a whole. Europeans used to define Africa as a 'mere geographical expression' not realizing that as Africans, we have our own culture, beliefs, ethics or philosophy, values, norms, religion, music to mention but a few, that gives us dignity as human beings. Europeans used to give Africans animalistic qualities, whiteness became the standard virtue and beauty and blackness becomes evil, and that thought was psychologically traumatizing, ontologically insipid and epistemologically insincere. This belief ended up affecting other Africans especially, the colonial Shona novelists who were influenced by the missionaries. This is what Chiwome (1996:11) remind us when notes that;

Popular authors grew up under church tutelage to become mission school teachers, lay and fulltime preachers...very few of these writers criticise the educational conditions of the time.

Chiwome's address captures the inherent causation of irrelevant authorship in Africa and Zimbabwe in particular. For instance, Chakaipa's *Garandichauya* (1963) clearly explicated this idea of relating white to beauty and black as ugly which was [is] meaningless to Africa and its people. The author says (through Muchaneta);

Akatanga zvakare kutaura ega, "Iye pano pasi pane munhu angandikunda kunaka here? Kana zvandakaita muchiringiro zvirizvo, hapana, kutosiya kwavakadzi vavaRungu vashomanana asi ruzhinji tinoenderana. Dai ganda rangu riri jena, chokwadi handaidai ndakawanikwa nomunhu mutema, asi hazvinei tichaona." (6)

In this world, is there anyone who is as beautiful as I am? If what I see in the mirror is anything to go by, then there is no one except a few white women, but I measure up to most

of them. If only my skin was white, truthfully speaking I would not have been married to a black person, but, anyway, we will see [time will tell].

She (Muchaneta) is simply implying that, white is beautiful and black is ugly and unattractive by that feeling of comparing herself to beautiful white women. This led Muchaneta to become an antihero whose character is widely discrepant from that which we associate with the African traditional protagonist or hero. Instead of manifesting largeness, dignity, power, or heroism among African people, she is trifling, ignominious, flaccid, ineffectual and individualistic. The colonised's aesthetic values have been shattered by "white supremacist ideologies that primitivize and pathologize black bodies" (McLaren in Mapara and Matereke, 2009:11). This view is deliberately obliterated by the native cultural Shona proverbial lore which is acting as a vivacious and vital force in deactivating such European mythological statements;

Munhu munhu hazvienzani nembwa.

(A human being is a human being, he cannot be compared to a dog).

From the above mentioned Shona proverb, any person, no matter how inferior and miserable, deserves respectful treatment. The proverbial lore above is cited for those who tend to degrade other people, in this case Europeans, simply because they perceive themselves as privileged ones. Rendering Conrad's words (1966:14), much later in life he said that until he visited Africa in 1890 he was 'just a mere animal'. He meant by these words that he experienced in Africa a peculiarly intense insight into the possibilities of evil in man.

The concept of giving animalistic qualities to Africans is also archetypal of Victorian racial thinking. As noted earlier on, this makes colonialism appear justified as there was need to enlighten and educate Africans and at the same time making Africans appear to be the source of the problems they were facing. According to Achebe (1981:251-261);

Heart of Darkness projects the image of Africa as "the other world," the antithesis of Europe and therefore of civilization, a place where man's vaunted intelligence and refinement are finally mocked by triumphant beastiality.

In Heart of Darkness, Conrad simply stated that depreciatory statement because he simply wanted to justify his mission into the interior. At first, his visit to Africa was an exploratory mission so what he saw when he first meet Africans was not visible. What he do saw when he do take a look

at Africans was what he wanted to invest in them. Before the coming of the whites, precolonial African societies had their own ways of perceiving the world around them, in this instance, they have their ways of interpreting person's beauty but due to the malicious activities of the colonialists, they tried to associate the colour black with evil. This is clearly revealed by the Shona proverbial lore which asserts the vicissitudes of colonialism;

Chirungu chakauya nechirungurira.

(Westernization brought indigestion).

From the above Shona transcriptional proverbial lore, Western ways have replaced African customs to an extent that the changes are referred to as epidemic. Prior to the Whiteman's encroachment into the interior, Africans used to consider the inner beauty of a person rather than considering the outer appearance (colour). With this proclamation, I'm not trying to assume that Africans did not recognise the physical appearance because they said black is ugly, NO! As Africans, they used to define beautiness relying on the philosophy of *Ubuntu* or *Hunhuism*, there were no colour variations, they do believe in the anatomy of being black. Fanon (1967) states that,

I am black; I am in total fusion with the world, in sympathetic affinity with the earth, losing my id in the heart of the cosmos -- and the white man, however intelligent he may be, is incapable of understanding Louis Armstrong or songs from the Congo. I am black, not because of a curse, but because my skin has been able to capture all the cosmic effluvia. I am truly a drop of sun under the earth.

Likewise, according to Ashimolowo, Homer the Greek is being said to have, 'placed blacks at a level as being as blameless as the gods'. But due to Whiteman's superiority complex, they have tried in whatever way they deem necessary to use in order to denigrate and vilify the native's image, gratify themselves with their imperial impulses. Nederveen Pieterse in Blackmon (2008: 6) observes that;

Images of the *noblesse sauvage* (noble savage), the redemption-seeking African in an Edenic setting, became popular in 19th century which Europeans used as proof that Africa's people needed to be controlled by an outside force and the *mission civilisatrice* became the cause behind the Christian invasion of the "Dark Continent"

At first glance, they came to Africa holding the bible as a way of persuading Africans to follow their so-called modern traditions and the very bible did not associate the colour black with evil at all, but red instead. Quoting the Jewish Bible, from Isaiah 1 vs. 18 it says;

Come now, and let us reason together, saith the LORD: though your sins be as scarlet, they shall be as white as snow; though they be red like crimson, they shall be as wool

Europeans are the ones that bring the bible into the interior but due to their malicious practices, they ended up contradicting themselves to justify their deeds. Whatever action Europeans took, only pleased them not Africans. They forget the notion that, being evil is not about skin colour, but the heart instead. The bible's view of beauty denotes that a supreme being (God) created man in his own image (Genesis 1: 26-27). We were (are) the same despite the fact of colour variation, if a mango tree has the capability of producing fruits with different taste, each and every fruit from that very same tree has its own luscious taste that makes it taste great in a unique way. Due to the Whiteman's unequal comparison between being black and white, they ended up referring to each and every illegal practice 'black'. This is clearly revealed in Pastor Rusukira's song 'Why'. The persona declares,

Why are you calling anything black evil?

As if you know the colour of the devil (Why)

Why calling an illegal market a black market? (Why)

Why black yet yellow, green and white are colours too? (Why)

...

Witchcraft and sorcery are evil acts practices in the whole world.

Why calling the practices black magic or black art

When there are so many colours on earth? (Why)

...

Why calling others black when they are brown? (Why)

Why calling others white when they are actually pink? (Why)

Why calling yourself white when you are pink? (Why)

Do you think you are so good? (Why)

Why calling yourself black when you are brown? (Why)

Do you think you are so bad? (Why)

Who knows the colour of the devil?

Him who knows the colour of the devil stays with him.

Having taking a closer look to the above transcribed song (poem), the persona's choice of the interrogative diction 'why' that he is applying frequently in the whole poem, it is clearly revealing his anger to the mounting body of falsified mythological rumors of relating everything illegal or evil to black. He is simply implying that, colour is not an adequate tool to use to identify a person's sense of beauty because black or white are just colours that have their own importance depending on specific culture. 'Indeed, in its original form of a poem in a musical setting, lyric is one of the most important kinds of African oral literature' (Finnegan, 1970:235). Because of such a rich heritage of African music, Africans are extremely operative in presenting to the world the true image of Africa and its people in the interior and abroad. Sometimes, a person can be bright or white in complexion but his or her actions are entirely evil and the vis-versa is relevant. In this case, there is a need to consider the inner beauty rather than outside beauty. This is elucidated by the Shona proverb which proclaims that,

Kuona roro kutsvuka kunze / nyamba mukati makadyiwa namakonye.

(A roro fruit can be red outside yet eaten inside by maggots.)

The outside appearance does not mean much. There may be serious defects of character in a good looking person. This is quoted, for instance, to dissipate a belief that a beautiful girl has also a perfect character. All is not gold that glitters.

You are supposed to be proud of being a black person because we give the world history. The word history itself would not be existing if there were no blacks. We are overcomers and what we overcame is what is called history today. Proverbs have entrenched messages in them, they were [are] not just mere expressions. All of the history and cultural norms of the Shona people in particular and Africa in general were hidden in these figurative phrases. So we were great historians and *Tsumo* or *Shumo* acted as historical facts. According to Carr (1961: 30),

My first answer (...) to the question 'What is history?' is that it is a continuous process of interaction between the historian and his facts, an unending dialogue between the present and the past.

Proverbs were able to reveal the past and at the same time being able to service the society's ideology and being capable to generate an ideological totalism among us. For example, our elders have been astute enough to enlighten us that;

Gunguo nyangwe rogeza sei / idema chete.

(No matter how thoroughly a crow may wash, it remains ever black).

OR

Nondo kugara mun'ombe / hanzi ndava n'ombewo.

(The tsessebe living among cattle/thinks he is cattle too).

The proverbs above are strictly denouncing the processes of assimilation and acculturation. Those Africans who tried to eliminate themselves from the native group in favour of White societies thinking that European culture is more superior to that of Africa which can sometimes be described as Quasi-African. As an African, you can only firmly rely on your own culture and not on alien cultures. This is clearly clarified by a Shona proverb which states that;

Tenda chaunacho / chesango hachisiri chako.

(Be grateful for what you have; that in the forest is not yours).

The aforementioned proverbial lore is instructing Africans didactically to be contented with what they have, including their colour, customs, cultural lores and regulations. Some Africans can even make use of cosmetics to their bodies in order to bleach the blackness in them and that is the main typical example of a culture of self-hate and hybridity. They are denying their status of blackness due to the outside cultural forces. This is what my colleague (Ngonidzashe Mupinda the poet) used to call self-slavery or *kuzvibopa* in Manyika dialect meaning, putting oneself on a yoke. The blackness in us must be protected because all the Africaness is conceived in that colour and someday that colour in us will be the proof to the world of our contribution to mankind.

To some extent, these European myths were a blessing in disguise to Africans because it led to the development and expounding of many African philosophies and histories to what became known as the 'rolling twenties' or the 'Negro revolution' like the Black Studies, Africology (study of Africana phenomena using Afrocentric perspective), Negritude, the Harlem Renaissance among others, which were mainly generated for Africans by Africans. Everything that reflects imperialism and colonialism, we reject it in totality. According to Eisenberg (2013:34);

The idea is that, once people know this true story of their own history, they shall be more able to resist the psychological and sociocultural effects of imperialism and its attendant racist dogma.

For instance, it gave Africans in the interior and those who were exported into the diaspora a room to write their own stories using their own worldview, writing their own history with the expression of venerable African tradition. Similarly, ‘it steered up the mutuality of knowledge with respect to the totality of impressions, thoughts and feelings of all black people, which was termed as the Black Consciousness’ (Manganyi, 1973: 10). With these events behind Africa and Africans, the fundamental reason here is that the Negro revolution of the 1930’s, is a movement for equality as well as for liberty. There are countless musical artists in Africa who have given people of Africa such a rich legacy of experiences through their music, and also paved the way for future musicians to express themselves fully. This revolt by Africans was also witnessed in South Africa during the apartheid era (1948-1994) where music played a crucial in fighting with the European racist dogma. Some of the musicians who were at the forefront of the struggle during the apartheid era were Vuyisile Mini, Miriam Makeba, Hugh Masekela, and Letta Mbulu. One of the anti-apartheid song that was sung is *Senzeni na?* (What have we done?), with the lyrics that follows;

Senzeni na? (What have we done?)

Sono sethu ubumnyama (Our only sin is that we are black).

The whole song is vigorously interrogating the evil actions of the whites towards Africans that was mainly orchestrated by racialism, by putting the native’s colour (black) on a grading scale. The main idea why the whites perpetuate with this act was that, they wanted to occupy our land, installing their novelistic culture that was alien to Africa and its people. This idea is captured by Muwati who notes that;

Kill them all; the unborn, the young, the old and even the “dead.” This perfectly phrases European behaviour and attitude towards people of other races, particularly people endowed with the greatest concentration of melanin – black people... It is an ideology of hatred, selfishness/monopoly, domination, control and power. This ideology gyrates around the scheme of superiority and big brother mentality.

European culture is characterised by individualism where they only care for themselves at the expense of other culture(s). This is against the African *Hunhu* or *Hunhuism* that unites instead of compartmentalising people which was termed by Chiwome (1996:11) as “sectarianism”. If Africans and Africa were [are] not black and dark respectively but brownish in complexion, so why did they called the indigenous and ancient land, ‘THE DARK CONTINENT’? This will lead us to a new sub-topic, ‘Why Africa was called Dark Continent?’

WHY AFRICA WAS CALLED ‘DARK CONTINENT’?

This infuriating and vexatious derogatory statement ‘Dark Continent’ was formulated by the Europeans referring to Africa for a reason. Europeans came here in Africa with nothing than a conflict of interest. The answer to the question, “Why was Africa called the Dark Continent?” is that Europeans assume that, they did not know much about Africa until the 19th century. But that answer is misleading, duplicitous and disingenuous. Europeans had known quite a lot about Africa for many years, but they pretended as if they don’t have knowledge regarding Africa because of powerful imperial impulses, European leaders began purposefully ignoring earlier sources of information. The main expounder of the pejorative and derogative statement, ‘Dark Continent’ was Henry Morton Stanley who was acting as King Leopold II of Congo’s forerunner in attaining land in Congo. Mudane (2017: 2) clarifies that,

During this period, [he] employed the famous explorer Henry Morton Stanley to map the Congo river basin and to conclude treaties with local African leaders, which in effect ceded their land to the king’s various associations, and thus to him.

In this regard, it is clear that, they referred to Africa as the ‘Dark Continent’ for themselves to justify their mission in the interior. At the same time, the campaign against slavery and for colonialism and the missionary work in Africa actually intensified Europeans’ racial ideas about African people in the 1800s. They called Africa the ‘Dark Continent’, because of the pandemonium, anonymities, mysteries and the savagery they expected to find in the interior.

HARASSMENT MOTIVATED BY RACISM

Discrimination reached its highest peak during colonial period when the Europeans were trying to justify their diabolic activities. Such racial segregation was much motivated by the White diabolocracy rather than democracy because Africans were always victims of the ploy, White

people always takes the gain while we (Africans) take the pain in return. People of African descent or parentage face widespread and entrenched prejudice and exclusion. This negative enactment is clearly revealed in Edward Dzonze's poem *Victims of the Ploy* (2018:46). The persona uttered that;

They wore God on their faces
To hide the devil in their thoughts
...
Far from our expectations
Their benevolence was a high way to hell
Dehumanized, Terrorized and traumatized
At their expedient behest professionals became laborers

Most of African descent experienced what they perceived as racist harassment due to the comparative weighing of colours, precisely, black and white. Experiences of racist aggravation most commonly involve offensive non-verbal cues or offensive or threatening comments. A good example is drawn from a particular video (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gw1BouLBJyg>) of Julius Malema a leader of South African opposition party, Economic Freedom Fighters (EFF) when he was asked a question by a Whiteman in a parliamentary meeting;

Whiteman: Why does he deliver a speech in a Whiteman's language of English and not in his own mother tongue?

Honorable Speaker: Honorable Malema are you prepared to respond to the question?

Julius Malema: I have no time for racist questions.

The question asked by a Whiteman seems to be a simple one but surely that question is offensive and callous. That system of 'ours and theirs' was mainly introduced by Europeans through their Western systems like capitalism and his twin brother colonialism. Colonialism had created a compartmentalised world (Fanon, 1963:3). There are three main types of harassment witnessed in the colonial and post-colonial Africa so far due to racism, for example, offensive or threatening comments in person, threats of violence in person, offensive gestures or inappropriate staring.

VIOLENCE MOTIVATED BY RACISM

Harassment was not the only kind of human mistreatment done to Africans, some African parentage experienced what is [was] perceived as the racist violence. During the colonial epoch some of the natives or African people experienced a racist physical attack and this included assault by the so-called Whites. Other Africans adopted such evil practices that is [was] alien to Africa. For instance; what is happening in South Africa today, they are busy attacking their brothers and sisters (foreign chauvinism), victimizing them in fatalistic manner to what is termed as Xenophobia. This is covered by Ngugi in the foreword of his book *Homecoming* (1972: viii) when he writes;

No people can become free, he observes, by adopting the political and economic systems that enslaves them... He has no illusions about Africa's liberation.

Before the Whiteman's encroachment into the interior, Africa was a peaceful continent where everyone lives in harmony and peace which were major elements of *Ubuntu*. It is the evil hand of colonialism that is behind the violence in African countries in this day and age. Colonial context is characterised by the dichotomy which imposes upon the whole people (Fanon, 1967: 35). Division is how Whites win and unity is how they crumble. They do not see people for who they are, instead, they see colours (black and white). They forget the notion that, colour only counts from the inside.

The typical example in Africa of experiences of corporal violence, which have been motivated by racism was witnessed in Congo under King Leopold II where Africans were tortured, mutilated, atrocities to mention but a few. He (King Leopold II) ended up earned the name 'Butcher of Congo' due to the harassment of the Africans due to racism which also includes unequal colour variation.

CONCLUSION

This paper clearly explicated the concept of beauty using an Aesthetical perspective which is an African phenomenon by the application of effervescent Shona proverbs (*Tsumo*) in particular and Africa in general. The traditional Shona people understood the concept of beauty in holistic terms, but as we discovered, it has changed partially, because of the Whiteman's encroachment and his activities in the interior, for instance, the influence of the missionary education and church to the natives. That is why there was a need to reconsider the cultural African definition of beauty, trying to revalorize its dignity from all the termination by the Whiteman's activities into the interior and

all its ramifications. Some of the effects of the Europeans in Africa was perpetuating falsified myths that did not only affect people of the past but including even the present and future generations, harassment and violence that were motivated by racism, misinterpretation of African history by the Whites to mention but a few. But as you have seen in this paper how our traditional Shona proverbial lores were able to restore the lost dignity, integrity and morality of Africans and all black people in the world, meaning these proverbs were (are) not just a 'mere figurative language' with no meaning. Another group of Shona people, specifically the Karanga speaking people of the Karanga dialect, pronounce the word *Tsumo* as *Shumo* which is translated as 'a message from elders that have the intention to express or convey and have a particular sense or meaning.' The statement above is conveyed by Hamutyinei and Plangger's expression, *Tsumo dzine shumoo* (Proverbs have sense/wisdom). Hence, this paper was able to explicate the notion of beauty and beautiful in Africa by recognizing the beauty of the colour black and beauty within, and also appreciating this aesthetics that manages to exterminate the affliction of black racism and revalorize and rebuild black people's lost identity due to the mischievous statements regarding the native skin.

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